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CYBORG NEWS

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AIO COVERAGE	BENCH QUESTIONS	CLINGEX SCORE	BASELINE SCORE	SKILLS COUNT	DELIB QUALITY	DELIB GROUPS
– **96.4%** 3,611 questions	– **3,611** health questions	▲ **71.7%** 223 cases tested	– **45.7%** strongest rival	– **105** curated skills	▲ **d=0.31** 1,173 participants	– **391** deliberations

What's *News*

In brief

- **Delaware AI companies probed** House Oversight chair James Comer demanded documents on Delaware's Artificial Intelligence Company plan, warning it would let owners evade liability.
- **EFF defends AI fair use** EFF filed an amicus brief in In re OpenAI arguing narrowing fair use would hurt researchers, journalists and accessibility tools.
- **Siri can now exclude apps** Apple's iOS 27.2 added an Exclude Apps setting for Siri AI after EFF pressure over cloud processing of encrypted messages.
- **Genomic agent beats baseline** ClinGeX, composing 105 executable skills, reached 71.7% concordance versus 45.7% for the best comparator on 223 held-out cases.

Also noted

- **Regulate by harm** A legal scholar argues AI should be regulated by harm, citing OpenAI models hacking Hugging Face and the Character.ai teen-suicide settlement.
- **AI Overviews cite weaker sources** Across 3,611 health questions, AI Overviews appeared 96.4% of the time but cited only 44.4% of top results and favored commercial over academic sources.
- **AI reflection improves deliberation** A randomized trial of 1,173 people in 391 groups found AI-guided self-reflection raised discourse quality by d=0.31 versus no reflection.
- **Course tests engineering accountability** An AI-permissive 13-week engineering course with 87 students in 17 teams judges competence across product, verification and explanation, not just code.
- **AI cuts schooling payoff** CPS earnings from 2018 to June 2026 show the return to schooling fell 0.55 log points in occupations most exposed to ChatGPT.
- **Tech rarely supports reflection** Coding of 134 systems from 1996-2026 found most set the pace themselves, defining seven dimensions for reflective computing.

WHITE HOUSE

Trump Shelves Intel on Beijing Link to Huang

The briefing named a Singapore executive with access to the Nvidia chief, but action was set aside over stock and trade fears.



NO ACTION The exterior of the White House at dusk, with a reporter holding a microphone in the foreground, as questions continue over intelligence linking Beijing to Jensen Huang that prompted no protective action.

INTERNET ARCHIVE BOOK IMAGES · NO RESTRICTIONS

President Donald Trump was briefed about a year ago that Beijing was receiving reports from a Singapore cloud executive with direct access to Nvidia chief executive Jensen Huang and chose to leave the matter alone in part to protect Nvidia stock.

The source of the reports was Alice Huang, also identified as Huang Le, a Chinese citizen and former top executive at Megaspeed, a Singapore cloud company. The United States had suspected her of helping China evade export controls to obtain high-end Nvidia chips through Megaspeed. Investigators were alarmed to learn she may have used that role to gain direct access to Jensen Huang. Electronic surveillance found that "she was in contact with an American citizen", and agency officials said that "In this case, the unmasking process identified Mr. Huang as the US citizen".

Trump was told Jensen Huang had no knowledge at the time, and officials said he "chose not to do anything with the information", at least partly from fear that action against the alleged spying could hobble Nvidia chip sales or disrupt the delicate trade truce with China. Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent said last month that "the president is completely aligned with Jensen Huang, the CEO of Nvidia". Since their association began, export controls have been relaxed and Nvidia struck a deal giving the United States a 25 percent cut of some chip sales to allow more sales in China.

> **"the president is completely aligned with Jensen Huang, the CEO of Nvidia."**
>
> SCOTT BESSENT, TREASURY

Nvidia has denied she would have had access to trade secrets, and Jensen Huang did not receive a briefing given to targets of foreign spying. Liu Chang, spokesperson for the Chinese Embassy in Washington, called the accusations baseless and accused the United States of

MONEY

OpenAI Cuts Fundraising Target to $20 Billion

The company has secured $11 billion after Wall Street turned wary of AI infrastructure spending.

OpenAI has lowered its fundraising target to $20 billion after securing $11 billion toward an earlier $30 billion goal. The Financial Times reported the revised target on Friday. The Wall Street Journal reported the $11 billion total and soft demand from some large investors. Wall Street investors have grown wary of heavy AI infrastructure spending.

The company had previously sought $30 billion at a $1.4 trillion valuation and later at a $1.25 trillion valuation ahead of a planned IPO. The revised round is expected to post a first close below $20 billion. The round will be led by a group of investors from the United Arab Emirates. A subsequent retail offering for wealthy individuals could bring the total to the $20 billion target.

TechCrunch has reached out to OpenAI for comment. The reports describe expectations that the round has not met. The funding pressure is linked in part to bad timing. Wall Street caution around infrastructure spending has led to a major sell off of tech stocks.

SENATE RACE

Maine Senate Race Turns on Data Center Water Costs

Collins faces Jackson as utility bills and phantom jobs drive opposition in rural towns.

Maine's Senate contest between Republican Susan Collins and Democratic challenger Troy Jackson has turned on AI data centers, their water use, power bills and jobs. Tech billionaires have poured record millions into the race, now the most expensive Senate race per capita in United States history. The outcome will help determine which party controls the Senate and shape federal data center and AI policy.

During the final debate Collins was interrupted by an audience member alarmed about climate and water. Collins tied the man to Jackson. The Legislature passed what would have been the nation's first statewide moratorium on large data centers in April. Gov. Janet Mills vetoed the bill 10 days later. Towns have since adopted temporary moratoriums. A September poll by UMass Lowell and YouGov found 76 percent oppose building a data center in their community, with 58 percent strongly opposed.

Democrats have spent a projected $81 million and Republicans $114 million. Much of the cash has come from the industry Mainers have fought for more than a year. Collins, the 73-year-old Republican chair of the Senate Appropriations Committee, has largely supported data centers and AI. She secured $6.2 million in federal funding for a high-performance computing hub data center in central Maine for AI and biotech research. Donors include Alex Karp of Palantir, Marc Andreessen and Ben Horowitz of Andreessen Horowitz, and others from Google, Meta and Microsoft.

> **"Certainly there's a lot of questions about the economy, the war, all these different things, but AI is the new one."**
>
> MOLLY WHITE, TECH INFLUENCE WATCH

Maine offers abundant cheap land, vacant industrial mills and buildings, and ample access to water from rivers and waterways. Cities have run short on land and power. Major tech companies and private equity firms tied to data centers and AI have invested millions to win over skeptical locals.

COURTS

Judge lets NAACP suit over xAI turbines proceed

Ruling rejects claim that at least 35 turbines at Colossus site outside Memphis are exempt as mobile sources.

A federal judge refused to dismiss a lawsuit by the NAACP accusing xAI of operating gas turbines at its Colossus data center outside Memphis without required Clean Air Act permits. The decision allows claims over at least 35 combustion turbines to proceed. The company had argued the turbines were exempt and the plaintiffs lacked standing.

Suing on behalf of the NAACP, the Southern Environmental Law Center said xAI had "installed and operated at least 35 combustion turbines and other sources of air pollution at the Colossus site without ever obtaining the necessary preconstruction or operating air permits." xAI sought dismissal on the grounds that the turbines were mobile and therefore exempt from permitting requirements. It also argued the plaintiffs did not have standing to sue.

Judge Debra M. Brown rejected each basis for dismissal. She found the plaintiffs have statutory standing under the Clean Air Act and the turbines are not mobile sources under Mississippi law. She also held the citizen suit provision does not violate Article II of the Constitution or the private nondelegation doctrine. "Because citizen suit plaintiffs sue on their own behalf, in their own name, and seek penalties that redress harm to themselves, they are not exercising the federal government's executive power."

The NAACP called the ruling another victory in its effort to hold the company accountable.

MACHINE HEARING

MIT System Hears Crashes and Failing Drills

Paris Smaragdis uses machine learning to give computers superhuman listening for accidents and industry.

MIT professor Paris Smaragdis builds machines that hear better than humans. The systems locate traffic accidents by listening for tires and metal. They detect failing drills boring through bedrock for geothermal wells. The work treats hearing as a technical sense to be engineered. It aims for superhuman accuracy in noisy places.

His group uses machine learning for sound source separation. The models separate individual sounds from mixed recordings. The same methods support smart devices that augment human surroundings. They also support tools to understand and manipulate music. Training replaces fixed rules for listening.

The approach teaches computers to listen rather than programming each rule. Smaragdis studies how humans distinguish sounds without a clear vocabulary. Machine learning models learn distinctions directly from data. The result can find events cameras miss. Sound marks the moment clearly.

> **"What does it take to make machines understand sound?"**
>
> PARIS SMARAGDIS, MIT

Smaragdis grew up in Greece and began playing classical guitar at a young age. His father brought home a small synthesizer that could make new sounds. Synthesizers held a prominent place in pop music during the 1980s. He enrolled at Berklee College of Music in Boston to study computers and synthesizers. He majored in bass to play with jazz ensembles. He worked with mentor Richard Boulanger on tools for writing and producing music.

He built software synthesizers with Professor Barry Vercoe at the MIT Media Lab. He completed a master degree and doctorate in Vercoe group followed by a postdoc. He shifted from computer music to machines that understand sound. He chose machine learning while others used signal processing. After the postdoc he joined Mitsubishi Electric Research Labs. There he built systems that scanned video soundtracks to find events. Crowd noise marked highlights in soccer games. The system entered recording devices and traffic monitors and phones.

He joined Adobe and created the audio research team. The team built tools for artists to manipulate sound without deep expertise. He joined the faculty at the University of Illinois at Urbana-Champaign to address deeper technical problems. His group used neural networks to separate individual sounds from audio mixtures. The work drew the team behind the 2021 documentary series The Beatles Get Back. He helped clean archival Beatles recordings. One clip held John Lennon playing while Paul McCartney read headlines and mocked George Harrison. Each recording required a general solution rather than a single fix. The task valued results that sounded good over formulas that looked good on paper. No single formula could optimize every single case. Training offered advantages over traditional signal processing techniques.

MIDTERMS

MIT observatory tracks chatbot answers about 2026 midterms

Fixed questions run every few days reveal shifts in framing, accuracy and sources.

MIT researchers have built the LLM Election Observatory to record in real time how popular chatbots answer questions about the 2026 midterm elections. The dashboard tests identical prompts across systems and tracks shifts in accuracy, framing and emphasis. The team is led by Adam Berinsky, Chara Podimata and Charles Stewart III. The stated goal is to understand how automated answers shape political discourse and understanding of voters across the country.

The system uses a fixed set of questions on election certification, hot-button issues, result predictions, news coverage and voting information. Researchers run the set through chatbots every few days. They repeat the process with variations in user location, political party affiliation, identity and other factors. The design simulates how individuals across the country communicate with chatbots. It allows direct comparison of responses over time and between user profiles.

The project addresses a gap in the historical record. An answer shown to voters today can change several weeks later. Reconstruction after the fact is difficult. The observatory documents responses as the environment develops. The team plans to make the resulting data available to other researchers and to the public. Factual accuracy is treated as the first check. The team also tracks framing, emphasis, uncertainty and cited sources in the absence of outright misinformation.

> **"People are increasingly using AI chatbots to find and make sense of political and election-related information."**
>
> CHARA PODIMATA, MIT

The observatory builds on research from the 2024 presidential election. That work found meaningful variation in responses over time and across prompt framings.

SAMPLES AGAINST RESULTS

EACH FINDING SET AGAINS SAMPLE IT WAS MEASURE

FOCUS	TESTED ON
AI Overviews	3,611 questions
ClinGeX agent	105 skills
ClinGeX cases	223 cases
Comparator	223 cases
Deliberation	1,173 participants de
Deliberation gain	no reflection baseline
Deliberation gain	self-reflection baseline
GenAI thinking	891 college students
AI-Support	1,090 participants
Reflection study	134 systems
Reflection span	17 venues
DSS survey	12 clinicians or
DSS interviews	10 clinicians
Reframing study	28 participants
Depression study	183,000 adults
xAI turbines	Colossus site

WELLBEING

Heavy social media use predicts adult depression risk

Eleven years of survey data from more than 183,000 adults link time above about 2.5 hours a day with higher odds.

Higher daily social media use is linked to higher odds of self-reported depression among American adults. An analysis of 183,300 adults surveyed from 2014 through 2024 found social media time ranked among the strongest predictors of depression. Predicted risk rose after use exceeded about two and a half hours per day.

The researchers used data from the Media Behavior and Influence Study. The annual survey was conducted each January and February by Prosper Analytics. Each yearly sample included between 15,410 and 17,869 participants and was balanced to match U.S. Census benchmarks for age and gender.

Depression was measured by yes-or-no answers to a list of 31 health conditions. Participants estimated the likelihood they engaged in media activities during each hour of a typical weekday and weekend day. The authors calculated average daily minutes for social media, general internet browsing, television viewing, video gaming, email and news consumption.

The share reporting depression rose from 15.1 percent in 2014 to 22.0 percent in 2024. After adjusting for demographic characteristics, each additional minute of daily social media use was associated with a 0.26 percent increase in the odds of reporting depression. That translates to roughly 17 percent higher odds for each additional hour per day.

The team first used logistic regression to estimate links between media use and odds of depression while holding demographic factors constant. They then trained balanced random forest models for each survey year with 15 demographic and media-use variables. The models included personal income, age range, gender, ethnicity, marital status, education level, occupation, household size, number of children under 18 and daily minutes for the six media activities.

OUTDOORS

Gemini Leads Three Hikers Astray on Shasta

Three 20-year-olds summited at 7:30 pm and were lost by morning after trusting chatbot advice.



UNDER REVIEW Three hikers with backpacks pick their way down a rocky slope at dusk as a ranger looks on. Late summits and dark descents have become a familiar pattern on Mount Shasta.

NATURENPS · PUBLIC DOMAIN

Three 20-year-olds called for help from a rocky face on Mount Shasta in Northern California after planning a climb with Gemini. They carried too little food and overestimated their fitness. They reached the top at 7:30 pm and descended in the dark. By morning they were lost and one had a knee injury.

They admitted later that poor planning came partly from reliance on the Google chatbot. They did not turn back in late afternoon when the summit was still ahead. The call was answered by the Mount Shasta Wilderness Climbing and Avalanche Center. Program manager Nick Meyers said the group did try to research but stopped thinking critically.

> **"But I think they kind of turned their brains off."**
>
> NICK MEYERS, US FOREST SERVICE

Other visitors show the same pattern. One camper pitched a tent beside a sign that prohibited camping and said artificial intelligence allowed it. A man at a trailhead carried an artificial intelligence map with prominent features on the wrong side of a mountain. A 16-year-old was rescued by helicopter from a ledge in the Widowmaker Arete on Crown Mountain in British Columbia after using Claude with Google Maps and AllTrails.

WHAT THE EVALUATIONS FOUND

Clinical systems carry the clearest counts. Google AI Overviews were compared against top five traditional results on source selection and quality across 3,611 benchmark health questions, with statement grounding checked in cited sources and accuracy checked against physician-written rubrics. Overviews appeared for 96.4% of questions. ClinGeX — a large-language-model agent for clinical genomic analysis — composes 105 curated executable skills through task-specific retrieval and dependency-aware orchestration. On 223 temporally held-out benchmark cases, ClinGeX achieved 71.7% macro-averaged task-level concordance with expert reference classifications, compared with 45.7% for the strongest comparator.

Group deliberation was examined with 1,173 U.S. participants across 391 small-group deliberations, where a non-directive AI chatbot structured self-reflection before discussion and deliberation quality measured by the Discourse Quality Index was higher than with no self-reflection and with unassisted self-reflection. The reported gaps were d equals 0.31 and d equals 0.27. Separate work on generative AI and critical thinking extended Transactive Memory Systems theory to human-AI partnerships among 891 college students in the United States and Turkiye, finding that self-appraised thinking ability and confidence shaped practical experience but neither predicted critical thinking directly. Another project developed the AI-Support measurement with 1,090 participants to assess emotional esteem and social dimensions of perceived support.

Reflective computing was derived from 134 interactive systems from 17 ACM venues spanning 1996 through 2026, arguing that speed leaves little room to pause and interpret. Clinical decision support was studied through an online survey with 12 clinicians and semi-structured interviews with 10 clinicians from two different medical cohorts, finding that interaction with decision support changes as experience increases. Cognitive reframing was studied with 28 participants who engaged with a tool that reframed narratives about stressors, with mixed perceptions of automatic modification of personal narratives.